Minh-Chau (James) Pham

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Research Interests

Labour economics; immigrant labour market outcomes; returns to education and retraining; earnings inequality; applied econometrics; machine learning in economics

Education

University of Saskatchewan — Saskatoon, Canada
MA in Economics — Aug. 2025 – Present (expected 2027)
GPA: 94.25% (all coursework completed)

WorldQuant University — Washington, DC, USA
MSc in Financial Engineering — Jan. 2025 – Present (expected 2027)
GPA: 94% (9/10 courses completed)

FPT University — Hanoi, Vietnam
MBA, FPT School of Business and Technology — Dec. 2022 – Apr. 2024
GPA: 8.80 / 10

National Economics University — Hanoi, Vietnam
BA in Economics (Mathematical Finance) — Sep. 2010 – Mar. 2014
GPA: 7.86 / 10

Publications

Journal articles

Pham, Q.-T., **Pham, M.-C.**†, & Vo-Thi, Y.-N. (2026). Drivers of self-reported destination loyalty intentions in an emerging tourism destination: A PLS-SEM study of tourists in Da Nang, Vietnam. *Innovative Marketing*, *22*(3), 321–334. https://doi.org/10.21511/im.22(3).2026.20

Pham, M.-C., Vo-Thi, Y.-N., Mai, T.-O. D. N., Nguyen, A.-Q., Phung, Q.-B., Le-Huu, T.-T., Do-Hoang, L.-N., & Pham, Q.-T. (2026). Enhancing perceived value in emerging tourism destinations: The role of destination image, experience, and satisfaction — Insights from Da Nang, Vietnam. *HUIT Journal of Science*, *26*(3E). https://doi.org/10.62985/j.huit_ojs.vol26.no3e.611

Nguyen-Le, D.-K., Tran, T. H., **Pham, M.-C.**†, Tu, H. T. H., & Nguyen, T.-C. (2025). EconVNNewsBot-2: Enhancing economic news retrieval with retrieval-augmented thoughts for improved question-answering in Vietnam. *The Journal of Data Science and Artificial Intelligence*. https://publications.isods.org/index.php/jdsai/article/view/43

Conference proceedings

Nguyen, D. D., Vo-Thi, D.-T., **Pham, M.-C.**, & Nguyen, P. N. (2026). Applications of machine learning and data augmentation in CPI forecasting for Vietnam. In *Proceedings of the Conference on Applications of Technology, Automation, and Civil Engineering (ATAC 2026)*, Ho Chi Minh City, 20 March 2026. **[Best Paper Award]**

Pham, M.-C., Vo-Thi, D.-T., Vo-Thi, Y.-N., & Pham, Q.-T. (2025). A hybrid CNN-SVM model augmented with technical indicators for forecasting the Vietnam stock market index. In *Proceedings of the International Conference on Management, Business, Economics, Law and Technology (COMBELT 2025)*. https://due.udn.vn/vi-vn/combelt-intro/cid/5776

Nguyen-Le, D.-K., Tran, T. H., **Pham, M.-C.**, Tu, H. T. H., & Nguyen, T.-C. (2025). EconVNNewsBot: Leveraging question answering system with retrieval-augmented generation and chain-of-thought reasoning for economic news in Vietnam. In *Proceedings of the 2024 Conference on Applications of Technology, Automation, and Civil Engineering (ATAC 2024)*. https://atac2024.aiotlab.vn/publications

†Corresponding author.

Working Papers

Under review

The Immigrant–Native Wage Gap in the Contemporary United States: An Oaxaca–Blinder and Machine Learning Analysis
with Thanh-Huy Le (Tien Giang University) and Gia Phuc Dao (Simon Fraser University)
Role: first author; corresponding author
Under review at *Social Sciences & Humanities Open*. Accepted for presentation at the 20th International Conference of the Thailand Econometrics Society (TES 2027).

Working paper

Enclaves and Earnings: Ethnic Concentration and the Labor-Market Outcomes of Vietnamese Immigrants
with Thanh-Huy Le (Tien Giang University)
Role: first author

Work in progress

Sheepskin Effects for Immigrants and Canadian-Born
Role: sole author
MA research project. Estimates the difference in sheepskin effects between immigrant and Canadian-born students in recent cohorts of postsecondary entrants in Canada: the gap in the earnings return to completing a credential, holding years of schooling constant. Re-examines Ferrer and Riddell (2008) with the Canadian credential directly observed. Proposed data: Postsecondary Student Information System (PSIS), T1 Family File (T1FF), and Longitudinal Immigration Database (IMDB), Statistics Canada Research Data Centre.

Weather Impacts on Agricultural Production, Agricultural Commodity Prices and Price Relationships: Evidence from the United States and Europe
with Minh Tien Phung
Role: co-author (second author)
MScFE capstone project, WorldQuant University (proposal stage). Examines how temperature and precipitation affect crop yields, and tests cointegration, error-correction dynamics, and the speed of mean reversion in corn–wheat and soybean oil–rapeseed oil price spreads in the United States and Europe. Code: https://github.com/chaupmbn/mscfe-capstone-weather-agri

Conference Presentations

20th International Conference of the Thailand Econometrics Society
Faculty of Economics, Chiang Mai University, Thailand — Jan. 2027
TES 2027, 6–8 January 2027 (scheduled)
"The Immigrant–Native Wage Gap in the Contemporary United States: An Oaxaca–Blinder and Machine Learning Analysis"

7th Asia Conference on Business and Economic Studies — Aug. 2025
ACBES 2025, UEH University, Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam (poster)
"Adaptive Portfolio Optimization in the Vietnamese Stock Market: A Contextual Multi-Armed Bandit with Markov-Switching Regimes"
with Thien-My Ngo and Dang-Khoa Nguyen-Le
Role: co-author (third author)

Research Experience

Research Assistant — Aug. 2026 – Present
A/Prof. Guido Matias Cortes, Dept. of Economics, York University
A/Prof. Kelly Foley, Dept. of Economics, University of Saskatchewan
Projects: *Who Enrolls in Post-Secondary Education During Recessions?*; *Post-Secondary-Education Institutions and Earnings Inequality*. Data cleaning, sample construction, and regression analysis.

AI Lab, AI VIET NAM — 2024 – Present
Research collaboration on machine-learning applications in economics and finance.

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, Dept. of Economics, USask — Fall 2026
Econ 801: Macroeconomic Theory (graduate) for A/Prof. Enchuan Shao

Teaching Assistant, Dept. of Economics, USask — Fall 2026
Econ 800: Microeconomic Theory (graduate) for Prof. Jingang Zhao

Teaching Assistant, Dept. of Economics, USask — Winter 2026
Econ 304: Introduction to Empirical Economics for A/Prof. Kelly Foley
Graded assignments; led weekly lab and theory help sessions.

Teaching Assistant, Dept. of Economics, USask — Fall 2025
Econ 111: Introductory Microeconomics
Graded assignments; held regular help sessions for first- and second-year students.

Honors, Awards & Grants

Best Paper Award — Ho Chi Minh City, Mar. 2026
Conference on Applications of Technology, Automation, and Civil Engineering (ATAC 2026)
"Applications of Machine Learning and Data Augmentation in CPI Forecasting for Vietnam"

Travel Grant, Cornell University — May 2026
Summer School in Research Reproducibility: Ensuring the Transparency and Credibility of Your Work, 2026 CEA Meetings, Vancouver

Dr. Krishan Lal and Sunita Lal Graduate Award in Economics
University of Saskatchewan — 2026

Graduate Scholarship
Dept. of Economics, University of Saskatchewan — 2025

Industry & Professional Experience

Sala Hotel Group — Danang, Vietnam
Managing Director — Jan. 2022 – Jun. 2025
Portfolio: 4 hotels (630 keys), 1 beach club restaurant (>1,000 seats), including a new 4-star hotel project in Quy Nhon.
Led cross-functional teams and hotel operations, aligning daily execution with strategic goals. Drove service-quality improvements through KPI monitoring, budgeting, and resource planning.
Group properties ranked #1 on Agoda in the Danang market and top 3 in Vietnam, top 5 on Booking.com and top 10 on Expedia in Danang, and #1 and #2 on all OTAs in the Tuy Hoa market, with guest review scores of 9.0–9.5/10.

Kim Tin Group Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam
Independent Member, Board of Directors Apr. 2021 – 2024
Chair, Audit Committee
Provided independent oversight of the company's governance and financial reporting, including monitoring management performance, transparency, and regulatory compliance. Led the Audit Committee's oversight of internal controls, risk management, and audit processes.

Diamond Sea Hotel Danang, Vietnam
Operations Manager Apr. 2016 – Mar. 2019; Oct. 2019 – Dec. 2021
Assistant to the General Manager Nov. 2014 – Apr. 2016
Led the pre-opening team and managed all operations of a 4-star property (126 rooms). Led the hotel's digital marketing and online travel agency (OTA) strategy; exceeded annual financial budgets by 10–15% (2014–2019). Kept the hotel operating through the COVID-19 pandemic, when most Danang hotels closed for over a year, while maintaining guest review scores of 8.8–8.9.

Freelance Consultant Mar. 2019 – Sep. 2019
Hotel Operations and Marketing
Advised hospitality clients on operational efficiency and marketing strategy: assessed hotel operations to identify improvements, and designed digital and traditional marketing plans for client properties.

Service & Outreach

Budget and Finance Committee Sep. 2025 – Present
Graduate Students' Association, University of Saskatchewan

Skills

Programming: Python, Stata, LaTeX (all proficient); MATLAB (familiar).
Software: Excel (financial modelling, dashboards, pivot tables).
Methods: Regression, panel-data, and time-series analysis; Oaxaca–Blinder decomposition; machine-learning forecasting.
Languages: Vietnamese (native), English (fluent).

References

Dept. of Economics, University of Saskatchewan

A/Prof. Kelly Foley	kelly.foley@usask.ca	+1 (306) 966-5209
A/Prof. Andreas Pollak	a.pollak@usask.ca	+1 (306) 966-5221
A/Prof. Enchuan Shao	enchuan.shao@usask.ca	+1 (306) 966-6251
Prof. Jingang Zhao	j.zhao@usask.ca	+1 (306) 966-5217

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